

KEY EVENTS

1914–45

■ **1915** The invention of the interrupter gear allows a pilot to fire a machine-gun through his propeller arc, leading to the development of the first fighter planes.

■ **1935** The UK begins work on an air defence system, based on a chain of coastal radar stations, to give early warning of aerial threats.

■ **1937** German aircraft intervening in the Spanish Civil War destroy the Basque town of Guernica by aerial bombing.

■ **1938** The Boeing B-17 Flying Fortress (see pp.314–17) heavy bomber is introduced. This all-metal monoplane can carry a 2,700kg (6,000lb) bomb load.

■ **1944** The German Messerschmitt Me 262 Schwalbe (“Swallow”) is the first jet-engined fighter to enter service.

■ **1945** American B-29 bombers drop atomic bombs on the Japanese cities of Hiroshima (see pp.378–79) and Nagasaki; Japan then surrenders.

► THE BOMBING OF DRESDEN

In February 1945, some 1,300 Allied bombers attacked the German city of Dresden, causing a firestorm that killed around 25,000 people. The incident became a focus for criticism of strategic bombing.

KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE GROWTH OF AIR POWER

The most influential innovation in warfare between 1914 and 1945 was the development of air power. Combat aircraft became not only a vital adjunct to army and navy operations, but also an instrument for direct attack upon the enemy’s homeland and infrastructure.

Although there had been a few minor uses of aircraft in war before 1914, it was World War I that saw the first true age of military aviation. The main combatants entered the war with about 500 flimsy flying machines between them. By 1918, the UK alone had 22,000 aircraft in service.

The prime functions of aircraft were that of reconnaissance and artillery spotting – giving army gunners feedback on where their shells had landed. Experimental raids were also mounted on targets behind enemy lines, with small bombs dropped by hand. Fighter aircraft were later sent up to shoot down bombers and reconnaissance planes, and, by 1916, fighters from opposing sides

were engaged in aerial combat over the Western front. Air aces, the most successful fighter pilots, were celebrated as “knights of the air”.

STRATEGIC BOMBING

Military chiefs soon realized that aircraft could also be used for strategic bombing – direct air attacks on enemy cities. Germany led the world in lighter-than-air flight, and their massive Zeppelin and Schütte-Lanz rigid airships launched night raids on London and other cities from 1915. Airships proved too slow-moving and vulnerable once the UK deployed night fighters in defence, and were replaced by heavier-than-air bomber aircraft. From



“Fighting in the air is **not sport**, it is **scientific murder**”

US PILOT EDDIE RICKENBACKER, *FIGHTING THE FLYING CIRCUS*, 1919

